Extracto: Parfit on a Kantian Principle

Passage taken from:
Parfit, Derek (2011), *On What Matters Vol.1*, Oxford: Oxford University Press.

p. 212 30 The Mere Means Principle

Using people, it is often claimed, is wrong. But this claim needs to be qualified. If we are climbing together, I might use you as a ladder, by standing on your shoulders. And I might use you as a dictionary, by asking you what some word means, or use you as a witness to my signing of my will. Such ways of using people are not wrong. What is wrong, Kant claims, is *merely* using people. As others say, 'You were just using me'.

According to what we can call

> *the Mere Means Principle*: It is wrong to treat anyone merely as a means.

How can we use people without *merely* using them? In explaining this distinction, we can first compare how two scientists might treat the animals in their laboratories. One scientist, we can suppose, does her experiments in the ways that are most effective, regardless of the pain she causes her animals. This scientist treats her animals merely as a means. Another scientist does her experiments only in ways that cause her animals no pain, though she knows these methods to be less effective. This scientist, like the first, treats her animals as a means. But she does not treat them *merely* as a means, since her use of them is restricted by her concern for their well-being.

Similar claims apply to our treatment of each other. According to one rough definition,

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> we treat someone *as a means* when we make any use of this person's abilities, activities, or body to help us to achieve some aim.

[. . .]

According to another rough definition,

> we treat someone *merely* as a means if we both treat this person as a means, and regard this person as a mere instrument or tool: someone whose well-being and moral claims we ignore, and whom we would treat in whatever ways would best achieve our aims.

[. . .]

[A few pages later, Parfit describes the following real-life example]

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> [W]hen my mother travelled on a Chinese river in the 1930s, her boat was held up by bandits, whose moral principles permitted them to take, from ordinary people, only half their property. These bandits let my mother choose whether they would take her engagement ring or her wedding ring. If these people treated my mother as a means, they did not treat her *merely* as a means.

[This selection does not contain an explicit conclusion. But can you see how to turn this passage into an argument that is relevant to the formula of humanity as an end in itself?]

Background / Set up

State the argument in outline

Explain Any Rationales for the Premises

Evaluate the argument

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